

Manufacture in India. Sell to the world.

Five priority sectors for foreign direct investment, backed by ₹1.97 lakh crore in committed government incentives and a \$776 billion import market that's still growing faster than India can supply it.

\$776.0bn

FY2025-26 import market

₹1.97L cr

PLI outlay, 14 sectors

+7%

GDP growth, FY2025-26

THE OPPORTUNITY

A \$776bn import market that outgrew its own supply base

India's imports grew nearly six times faster than its exports over the last five fiscal years — the exact gap that import-substitution manufacturing investment is built to close.

MERCHANDISE IMPORTS, FY25-26

\$776.0bn

+26.6% over 5 years — the demand base for local manufacturing

MERCHANDISE EXPORTS, FY25-26

\$441.7bn

+4.7% over 5 years — India as a re-export & assembly base

IMPORT / EXPORT GROWTH RATIO

5.7x

The capacity gap this deck's sectors are built to close

For an investor, that gap is the pitch: India already buys these goods from somewhere. The question is whether they get made **in** India, with a government actively subsidizing the transition through Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes.

WHY NOW

A government actively de-risking the first mover

836

PLI applications approved

Across 14 sectors as of Dec 2025, ₹28,748cr already disbursed, 14.39 lakh jobs created.

+75.6%

Services surplus growth, 5yr

A structurally strong external balance — India can absorb a larger goods deficit while it builds capacity.

96.37

₹/US\$, 17 Jul 2026

A weaker rupee lowers dollar-denominated setup costs and improves export-side margins for a new plant.

This isn't a generic "India is growing" pitch. It's five specific sectors where a scheme is already funded, a supply gap is already measured, and — where relevant — an export channel to the US, EU, or Gulf already exists.

Electronics & Semiconductor Manufacturing

HS84–85 · India's single largest and fastest-growing high-tech import chapter — and the one chapter where policy support is already the strongest in the whole ledger.

Import value, FY25-26		\$104.9bn
8-year growth		+101.5%
Export growth (same chapter)		+324.1%

POLICY BACKING

India Semiconductor Mission 2.0 (₹76,000 crore) plus PLI Electronics/Mobile/Telecom — the strongest-matched chapter on either side of India's trade ledger. Currently 62% import-dependent on China for components: **the exact capacity gap a new fab or assembly plant fills directly.**

The investment case: government co-funding already committed, a domestic demand base of \$104.9bn/year, and a proven re-export channel — this same chapter is India's fastest-growing export line too.

Specialty Steel & Metals

HS72–73 · The rare chapter matched on both the import-substitution and export-growth sides of the same ledger.

PLI COMMITTED (1.0/1.1 + 1.2)

₹55,993cr

≈\$6.6bn at period-matched rates — one of the largest single PLI levers

PRODUCTION TARGET, FY26-27

42 Mt

explicitly sized to cut import dependency

EXPORT VALUE, BOTH CHAPTERS

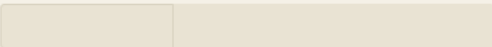
\$20.7bn

HS72 + HS73 combined, FY2025-26

Round 1.2 alone: 85 projects, 55 companies, ₹11,887 crore, 8.7 million tonnes of new capacity, MoUs signed February 2026. **Genuine white space remains** for capacity beyond what's already been awarded — India still imports \$15.8bn of iron & steel a year.

Auto, EV & Battery Storage

HS87 · A budget that nearly tripled in one year, and an export base already reaching five continents.

PLI Auto, FY26-27 budget		₹5,940cr
FY25-26 budget (prior year)		₹2,091cr
Vehicle export growth, 8yr		+43.5%

ESTABLISHED EXPORT LANES

USA, Mexico, South Africa, Saudi Arabia, UAE — already India's top-5 vehicle export destinations. The complementary **ACC Battery Storage PLI** (₹18,100cr, 50 GWh target, 40 GWh already awarded) feeds the same EV value chain.

The investment case: the fastest-scaling PLI budget in this deck, a market already exporting to 5 continents, and battery-storage capacity being built out in parallel.

Pharmaceuticals & Bulk Drug APIs

HS29/30 · India already leads the world in generic medicines. The gap is upstream — active pharmaceutical ingredients.

INDIA PHARMA + API EXPORTS

\$35.8bn

vs. ~\$1.3 trillion in global demand (NITI Aayog, 2025) — vast headroom

PLI BULK DRUGS

₹6,940cr

48 projects selected, 34 already commissioned

IMPORTS AVOIDED SO FAR

₹1,483cr

directly attributable to the scheme's early cohort

India remains roughly 70% dependent on China for API raw materials — the precise dependency this scheme targets. Telangana, Gujarat and Maharashtra are the established manufacturing clusters, with global-standard regulatory infrastructure already in place.

White Goods Components

AC compressors, copper tubes, aluminium foils (HS84) · A fully-subscribed scheme with a long committed production runway still to fill.

COMPANIES SELECTED

85 / 85

all four selection rounds complete — a mature, de-risked scheme

COMMITTED INVESTMENT

₹11,198cr

4-6% incentive on incremental sales through FY2028-29

CUMULATIVE PRODUCTION TARGET

₹1,90,050cr

the demand runway component suppliers are building against

The investment case: this scheme is closed to new PLI applicants, but that's the point — it signals a mature, proven supply chain a component manufacturer or Tier-2 supplier can plug into today, backed by a production target that runs to 2029.

Three sectors, no PLI yet — no incumbent to out-compete

Real, growing, unmet demand — with no Production Linked Incentive scheme in place. The first credible entrant sets the terms.

Inorganic Chemicals

HS28

\$14.2bn

import value, growing +86.0% over 8 years

Plastics

HS39

\$22.2bn

import value, growing +45.8% over 8 years

Aircraft & Spacecraft

HS88

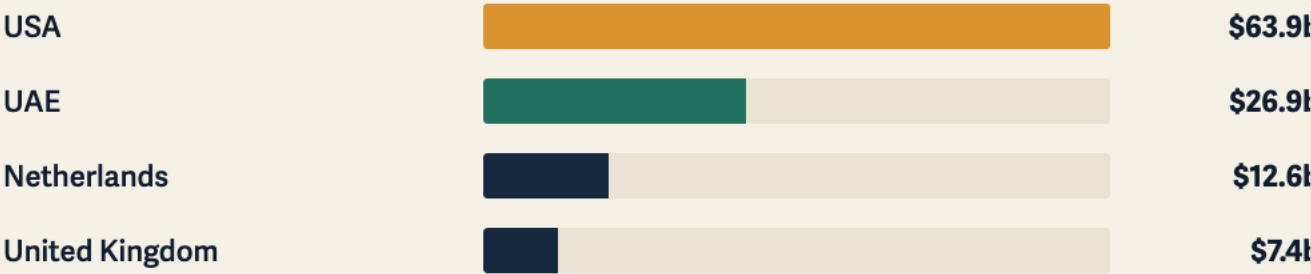
\$13.8bn

import value, growing +80.9% over 8 years

These are the cleanest import-substitution candidates this analysis found: real value, real growth, and — unlike the five sectors above — no existing scheme or funded competitor to negotiate around.

Manufacture here, and the export channel already exists

India's fastest-growing export chapters already reach the world's largest buyers — a new plant inherits the channel, not just the domestic market.



COMBINED EXPORT EXPOSURE BY DESTINATION, TOP 12 GROWTH CHAPTERS

The USA alone is the top-8 destination in 11 of India's 12 fastest-growing export chapters. That's an established, deep buyer relationship a new manufacturer can sell into from day one — not a market that needs to be built from scratch.

Two risks worth pricing in, honestly

An investment case is only credible if it names its own risks. Both below are real, quantified, and manageable — not reasons to pass, reasons to structure around.

CARBON BORDER RISK (CBAM)

\$20.7bn

of India's steel exports (HS72/73) sit inside the EU Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism's initial scope. Specialty Steel PLI scales production; it doesn't by itself address the carbon-cost exposure. **Structure for it:** pair new capacity with lower-emissions production routes from day one.

CURRENCY VOLATILITY

+11.9%

rupee depreciation in the 12 months to July 2026 — faster than the prior decade's ~3.3%/year average. Favorable for dollar-cost setup and export margins now; underwrite financing assumptions against continued volatility, not the current spot rate alone.

Full sourcing and methodology: herrickshaw.github.io/india-trade-sector-policy-recommendations

NEXT STEPS

Five sectors, one window — while the incentive is still open

Electronics, Specialty Steel, Auto/EV/Battery, Pharma APIs, and White Goods components each carry funded government backing today. Inorganic Chemicals, Plastics, and Aerospace remain open ground floor.

FACILITATION

Invest India

National Investment Promotion & Facilitation Agency

POLICY

Ministry of Commerce & Industry

Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade

FULL ANALYSIS

github.com/herrrickshaw

india-trade-sector-policy-recommendations